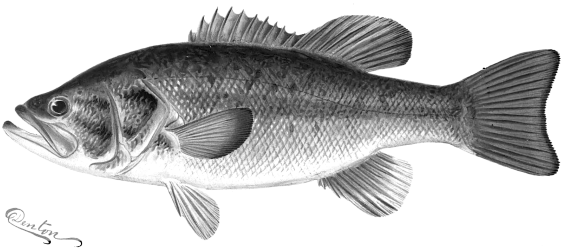


Largemouth Bass

The weed-edge ambusher — Pine Lake & North Lake

Micropterus salmoides



The Large-Mouthed Black Bass — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart

The jaw. On a largemouth the upper jaw reaches *past* the back of the eye; on a smallmouth it stops under the eye. Largemouth are green with one ragged dark stripe down the side, and the dorsal fin is pinched almost in two.

Size here

12–16 in is a normal fish, 18 in is a good one, 20 in is a trophy for these lakes. State record 11 lb 3 oz.

Spawn

Beds in 1–4 ft of sand or gravel in protected bays when the water holds 60–65 °F — late May into June. The male fans the bed and guards the fry for weeks afterward.

Eats

Anything it can fit: bluegill, perch, crayfish, frogs, young of its own kind.

Season

J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D
Dawn			Mid		Dusk			Night			

Time of day

Where

- Pine

Spots **5** (west shelf), **6** (west bay), **7** (south-east bay). The water is so clear that the weed line runs to 15–20 ft, and so does the bass. Do not stop fishing at 8 ft because that is where you would stop on a normal lake.
- North

Spots **1**, **4**, **5**, **7**. Stained water pulls them shallow — 4–10 ft is the band.
- Structure

Weed edges, isolated weed clumps, fallen wood, docks, and any hard-to-soft bottom transition. A largemouth wants something to hide behind and open water to charge into.

How

- In the weeds

Texas-rigged plastic worm or creature bait, *see the **Texas rig** sheet*. Weedless, sinks slowly, comes through everything.
- Pressured or clear

Weightless wacky-rigged worm, *see the **wacky rig** sheet*. On Pine Lake in bright sun this out-fishes everything else.
- Deep

A jig-and-craw or a Carolina rig on the outside weed edge, *see the **Carolina rig** sheet*.
- First and last light

A walking topwater or a popper over the weed tops. The best half hour of the day.
- For a beginner

A nightcrawler under a slip bobber set to hang just above the weeds. It is not fancy and it works.

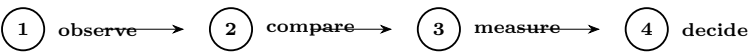
The one thing to remember

Largemouth relate to *cover*, not depth. Find the edge — of the weeds, of the shade, of the drop — and fish it. In the middle of a featureless flat there is no bass.

Worth knowing

How old is it?	In water this cold, a largemouth reaches about 12 in in four years, 15 in in six, and 18 in in eight to ten. The 20 in fish you are hoping for is older than the boy holding the rod.
It lives in a small world	Tagging studies consistently show largemouth holding home ranges of only a few acres, often returning to the same log or dock edge for years. A good spot is good repeatedly — which is why the numbered spots on the lake sheets are worth learning.
It hears with its body	The lateral line detects pressure waves at a few metres — a bass finds a lure in muddy water or full dark by feel. This is why a thumping spinnerbait blade works at night and a silent finesse worm does not.
It eats by suction	That bucket mouth opens fast and the fish inhales a volume of water. It is why a slack-line take feels like nothing, and why fixed-position baits like a wacky worm get eaten so confidently.
Cold shuts it down	Below about 50 °F a largemouth’s metabolism drops so far it may feed once every several days. That is not a fish being fussy — it genuinely does not need your lure.

Prove it in hand



Ask first	With the mouth closed, does the rear of the upper jaw extend beyond the eye?
Rule out	Smallmouth jaw ends under the eye and its dorsal fin is not deeply pinched; ignore colour alone.
Measure	Close the mouth, pinch the tail only if the rule says to, and read total length against a rigid board: press the snout to the board stop and read the longest tail tip without stretching.
Field proof	Jaw reach and dorsal shape must agree before counting it as largemouth. Photograph the whole side profile and the decisive feature before release if the identification remains uncertain.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 14 in minimum, 5 per day, open 2 May–7 March. Catch-and-release open all year. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

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